past, like cages associated with a gendered identity. Feminism is the language of male oppression and class struggle and it shows no flexibility to account for diverse experiences. Improvements in economic condition and education are not considered transformative enough. All contestations are about the woman's body. The hippie culture of the West in the 60s and 70s became the coda of this stream of thought. It is, therefore, natural for most women to be uneasy with Western feminist thinkers and their tropes, which have come to inhabit the social science space in India. In any case, whatever pretensions it had as an academic discipline soon degenerated into a fad and reckless lifestyle choices … It can be safely stated that the march of women's empowerment in India has no traces of Western feminist thinking. It follows the Indian trajectory of integration, where women and men work together to remove social ills that are incapacitating for women.

In other words, the BJP and the RSS talk of a new Indian model of feminism, focused as much on the family as it is on women's empowerment. The Sangh says 'it is reaching out to families with the message of women's empowerment, education, democratic participation and fighting evil practices like dowry. If a woman wants to go out for studies or work, she ought to be encouraged. If a woman decides to enter public life, she should be supported. We are seeing this change quietly sweep across the country in a uniquely Indian manner.'[149]

This notion of feminism is more sophisticated than what most liberals believe it to be. The default view has been that it aimed at 'maintain[ing] the highly subordinate position of women in India'.[150] The reality is different and much more complex. Swati Dyahadroy's work on Dnyana Prabodhini (DP), founded in 1962, has shown, for instance, that its women's wing had women doing things that men normally did, like beating drums in religious processions and learning martial skills. This countered the patriarchal idea of women's bodies and 'physical separation in public'. As Dyahadroy wrote, 'Women, thus, enter the public space claiming hitherto male domains by performing feats considered masculine in nature like beating drums, doing the lezim (local dance form similar to the drill) but encircled by